

Using the uploaded source doc as canon: *The Monster Nursery*, Liora Vale, Municipal Monster Control, the condemned mooncalf intake, Briarwick Monster Nursery, a care-based Sanctuary System, the 7-day license clock, trust percentages, moonwell repair, Hearthglow, and the unknown egg hook.

Episode 1

Intake: One Illegal Mooncalf

Liora Vale had stamped **CULL** on ninety-three forms that morning, and by lunchtime the word had started looking back at her.

It sat there in red municipal ink, blocky and final, across the top of Form 18-C: *Pest-Class Monster Disposal Authorization*. It sat there on Form 42-B: *Defective Hatchling Liability Transfer*. It sat there on Form 77-F, which had recently been renamed *Compassionate Containment Outcome* by someone in the Department of Public Mood who clearly slept very well at night.

The form beneath Liora's hand concerned a nest of gutter imps found in the chimney of a bakery.

Known risks: flour theft, soot tracking, inappropriate giggling.

Recommended action: cull.

She looked at the line for approving clerk signature.

Then she looked at the attached witness statement.

> "They ate two trays of buns and taught my oven to sneeze."

Liora rubbed the bridge of her nose.

Across the room, the Municipal Monster Control Office clattered and wheezed around her like an elderly machine that had developed strong opinions about misery. Pipes ticked in the walls. Quills scratched. Brass filing cabinets sneezed dust whenever someone opened a drawer. Somewhere near Receiving, a trapped shriekmoth was doing a convincing impression of a kettle boiling to death.

At the next desk, Pollard dipped his stamp into red ink and brought it down with the peace of a man who had never once questioned a form.

CULL.

Stamp.

****CULL.****

Stamp.

****CULL.****

He hummed while he worked.

Liora found that offensive.

Not the humming, exactly. Pollard's humming was tuneless but not aggressive. It was the ease. The way he could reduce a living thing to a line item before his tea went cold.

"They're gutter imps," Pollard said without looking up. "They breed in soot. Nasty little things."

"They taught an oven to sneeze."

"Which is a public hazard."

"It sneezed cinnamon."

"Still a hazard."

Liora glanced at the bakery owner's note again. At the bottom, in shakier handwriting, someone had added: *The smallest one cried when the baker's boy shouted.*

She turned the form over and reached for a yellow routing slip instead.

Pollard stopped humming.

"Liora."

"I'm sending them to Relocation."

"Relocation is full."

"Relocation is always full. That's why they keep issuing bigger clipboards."

"That is not how capacity works."

"It is how municipal capacity works." Liora wrote quickly. "If the clipboard has enough boxes, someone will invent a cupboard to put the problem in."

Pollard stared at her as though she had just proposed giving the gutter imps voting rights and tiny hats.

At the far end of the office, Head Clerk Grindle's door opened.

Everyone sat a little straighter.

Grindle was not a tall man, but he had cultivated an atmosphere of height through posture, shoe polish, and the sort of moustache that looked like it had been trained to detect insubordination. His waistcoat was immaculate. His cuffs were knife-white. His spectacles hung on a chain over a chest full of departmental pins, each one awarded for excellence in not making things better.

"Vale," he called.

The office went quiet in the way prey animals went quiet.

Liora set down her quill.

"Yes, Head Clerk?"

"Receiving. Special intake. Bring your stamp."

That was never good.

Special intakes meant things with too many legs, too few records, or relatives in politics. Sometimes all three.

Liora picked up her stamp, wiped the red ink from its face with a rag, and followed the central aisle past desks stacked with horn permits, claw complaints, and one glass jar containing a tiny thundercloud labelled *EVIDENCE — DO NOT SHAKE*. The thundercloud flashed sulkily as she passed.

Receiving occupied the back of the building, where the windows were barred, the floor was scratched, and the air smelled of wet straw, old wards, and whatever the city sweepers had dragged in before breakfast. Three containment crates waited beneath the loading hooks.

Two were ordinary.

The third was humming.

It was small enough to fit under a desk, made of ashwood slats banded in iron, and stamped on every side with a warning in red wax:

****DEFECTIVE — DESTROY BEFORE DUSK****

Something inside it shivered.

Liora's fingers tightened around the stamp.

Grindle stood beside the crate with a manifest board tucked beneath one arm. A courier in a rain-dark cloak waited near the door, clearly eager to be somewhere else. His boots had left muddy crescent moons across the floor.

"What is it?" Liora asked.

"Lunar calf variant," said Grindle. "Mooncalf. Juvenile. Unlicensed birth. Malformation probable. Panic-bound. Refuses feed. Possible contamination from illegal breeding ring outside the north marsh."

The crate shivered again.

Not violently. Not dangerously.

Miserably.

Liora crouched before the slats.

Inside, pressed into the far corner, was the smallest mooncalf she had ever seen.

It should have been silver-white, plush and round, with long ears soft as milkweed and tiny crescent horns that glowed under moonlight. That was what the registry illustrations showed. That was what nursery advertisements had once painted on tins of mineral milk before the nurseries were defunded, condemned, bought, sold, forgotten, and turned into cautionary footnotes.

This one was grey with grime. Its coat clung to its narrow ribs. One crescent horn was chipped. Its hooves were too large for its trembling legs, and its wide black eyes reflected every lantern in Receiving as if the whole room had frightened itself into them.

A paper tag hung from the crate latch.

No commercial value.

The mooncalf made a sound.

Not a bleat. Not a cry.

A small, broken hiccup.

Liora's throat closed.

"Oh," she said.

Pollard, who had followed at a safe distance because office tragedy was apparently more interesting than paperwork, leaned around a filing trolley. "Bit pathetic, isn't it?"

The mooncalf flinched.

Liora stood so fast the stamp nearly slipped from her hand.

"Don't."

Pollard blinked. "Don't what?"

"Make yourself the worst thing that happened to it today. It's a high bar, but you're ambitious."

The courier coughed into his sleeve. It might have been a laugh.

Grindle did not laugh. Grindle had probably filed a complaint against laughter in 3 copies.

"Vale," he said, crisp as folded parchment. "You are here because this office requires an approving clerk of adequate seniority to process immediate disposal."

"I'm senior enough for disposal but not senior enough for a chair that doesn't pinch?"

"Do not be glib."

"I'm not glib. I'm uncomfortable. The chair is one of several reasons."

Grindle's moustache twitched. "The creature is defective."

"It's starving."

"It is panic-bound."

"It's terrified."

"It has no registered owner, no licensed enclosure, no commercial value, and no available placement."

Liora looked back at the crate.

The mooncalf's ears trembled. It had tucked its nose against its own chest as if trying to take up less space in the world.

No available placement.

That was the sentence that did most of the killing. Not claws. Not teeth. Not venom. Not curses.

No available placement.

Liora knew the regulations. She had memorized them years ago, when she still thought good clerks could become good officials and good officials could become people who changed things. She knew that unlicensed monsters of uncertain risk had to be destroyed by dusk unless transferred to an approved sanctuary.

She also knew there were no approved sanctuaries left in the district.

There had been once.

Briarwick.

The name rose in her mind like a warm light behind a dirty window.

Briarwick Monster Nursery had been famous when she was small. Her aunt had owned a biscuit tin with its painted crest: a mooncalf asleep beneath a greenhouse roof, a basilisk chick wearing a ribbon, a ridiculous motto in curling gold letters.

Small claws. Soft hearts. Second chances.

Then the funding dried up. Then the inspections became stricter. Then the newspapers discovered that fear sold better than care. Then monster nurseries became "legacy hazards" and "unprofitable liabilities" and "a regrettable relic of a sentimental age."

Liora still had the tin at home.

She kept buttons in it.

Grindle held out the disposal form.

"Sign and stamp."

The mooncalf hiccuped again.

Liora stared at the blank signature line.

Her hand knew the shape of obedience. Pick up quill. Sign name. Press stamp. Move form to outgoing tray. Go home. Heat soup. Sleep badly. Return tomorrow. Do it again.

Her hand did not move.

“Vale,” Grindle said.

“No.”

The word landed softly.

Everyone heard it anyway.

Pollard’s mouth opened.

The courier took one slow step toward the door, then seemed to think better of missing whatever happened next.

Grindle blinked. “Pardon?”

“No,” Liora repeated, louder this time. Her voice shook. She hated that. She continued anyway. “I’m not signing an immediate disposal for a juvenile mooncalf whose listed crimes are being hungry, illegal, and inconvenient.”

“This is not a philosophical society.”

“I noticed. There would be more biscuits.”

“The law is clear.”

“The law allows transfer to an approved sanctuary.”

“There are no approved sanctuaries in this district.”

“Then reopen one.”

A tiny silence followed.

Somewhere in the office, the thundercloud jar gave a delighted little rumble.

Grindle looked at her as if she had suggested they replace all municipal stamps with interpretive dance.

"Briarwick's license was suspended twelve years ago," he said. "Its holding structures are condemned. Its owner is deceased. Its fees are unpaid. Its land is under review."

"But not demolished."

"No."

"And not reassigned."

"No."

"And its founding charter still exists."

Grindle's eyes narrowed.

There it was. The small twitch. The bureaucrat's flinch. The moment a forgotten clause poked its head above the paperwork and waved.

Liora knew forms. Forms were terrible. Forms were also doors. Most people only saw where they closed.

She saw hinges.

"The Briarwick charter," she said, heart thudding now, "states that in the absence of an appointed director, emergency custodianship may be granted to any qualified municipal employee willing to assume legal responsibility for the intake, stabilization, and rehabilitation of a condemned juvenile monster."

Pollard whispered, "That can't be real."

"It is real," Grindle said, which meant he wished very badly that it were not. "It was written in 1842."

"Good year for hinges."

"It has not been invoked in decades."

"That sounds like a scheduling issue."

"It requires personal liability."

"I assumed."

"It requires inspection within seven days."

"I can count that high."

"It requires the custodian to reside on-site until license review."

"I have been looking for cheaper rent."

"Briarwick has no staff."

"I have met the staff here, and frankly that may be an advantage."

Pollard made an injured noise.

Grindle's face reddened from the collar upward. "You are being reckless."

Liora looked down at the mooncalf.

Its eyes had fixed on her through the slats. They were still enormous. Still frightened. But one ear had lifted.

Not hope.

Not yet.

But attention.

"No," Liora said quietly. "I've been reckless for four years. I called it having a stable job."

Her hand dipped—not into red ink, but into the drawer of Grindle's manifest board. Before he could stop her, she took out the green stamp reserved for transfers, the one used so rarely that dust clung to its handle.

Pollard actually gasped.

Liora pressed it onto the form.

****EMERGENCY SANCTUARY HOLD****

The letters glowed.

The entire Receiving room exhaled.

Then the crate latch snapped open by itself.

A key fell out.

It was old, iron-dark, and warm enough to steam in the cool air. Its bow was shaped like a curled leaf. Its teeth looked less cut than grown. Green-gold light pulsed through the metal once, twice, then sank into Liora's palm as if it knew her.

The world chimed.

Not like a bell.

Like a spoon tapping the side of a teacup in another room.

A translucent panel unfolded in the air before her.

...

[SANCTUARY SYSTEM ACTIVATED]

Custodian: Liora Vale

Facility: Briarwick Monster Nursery

Status: Condemned

Core Function: Care-Based Progression

First Intake: Lunar Mooncalf

Condition: Malnourished | Panic-Bound | Lunar Depletion

Risk: Low immediate danger. High emotional fragility.

Objective: Stabilize creature before moonrise.

Reward:

- Nursery License Trial: 7 Days
- Custodian Ledger Access
- Initial Hearthglow generation enabled

Note: Thank you for choosing care.

...

Nobody spoke.

The mooncalf sneezed.

A tiny puff of silver dust drifted from its nose and settled on Grindle's shoe.

For the first time in four years, Liora laughed at work.

It came out startled and too bright, and perhaps a little close to crying, but it was laughter. Real laughter. The mooncalf blinked at her as if deciding whether laughter was edible.

Grindle stared at the system panel with the expression of a man watching a long-dead regulation climb out of its coffin and ask for tea.

“This is highly irregular.”

The panel pulsed.

...

Irregularity acknowledged.

Would you like to file a complaint?

Estimated complaint processing time: 6–8 weeks.

Mooncalf stabilization window: 5 hours, 42 minutes.

Recommendation: Prioritize mooncalf.

...

The courier made a choking sound and turned it into a cough.

Liora tucked the key into her fist.

“I’ll need transport.”

“You’ll need a psychiatric evaluation,” said Pollard.

“I’ll put in a request after moonrise.”

Grindle recovered enough to snatch the manifest board against his chest. “This office is not liable for your decision.”

“No,” Liora said. “I am.”

That should have frightened her.

It did.

But fear, she was discovering, felt different when it was attached to something alive.

She knelt and opened the crate properly.

The mooncalf did not rush out. It pressed itself flatter into the straw, every delicate bone trembling. Its chipped horn gave off a weak, intermittent glow like a candle trying not to go out.

“Hello,” Liora said softly.

The mooncalf stared.

“My name is Liora. I’m bad at making jam, good at finding loopholes, and apparently your emergency custodian.”

The mooncalf’s nostrils quivered.

“I don’t know what I’m doing,” she added. “But I know what I’m not doing.”

She held out both hands, palms up.

The mooncalf stared at them for a long while.

Then, with the sorrowful dignity of a creature expecting the world to disappoint it, it unfolded one ridiculous long leg, stepped forward, tripped over its own hoof, and collapsed nose-first into her lap.

Liora froze.

A tiny crescent horn poked her waistcoat.

The mooncalf made a damp little noise against her skirt.

Pollard whispered, “Is that normal?”

Liora looked down at the shivering bundle of ribs, ears, and soft grey fluff.

“No idea,” she said.

The system chimed.

...

[INTAKE UPDATE]

Lunar Mooncalf has initiated emergency contact.

Bond Trust: 0% → 3%

Status Effect Applied: Provisional Safety

Creature Nickname Available.

Warning: Creature requires appropriate habitat, reflected moonlight, and mineral milk before moonrise.

Ordinary feed may worsen Lunar Depletion.

Suggested destination: Briarwick Monster Nursery.

Suggested urgency: brisk.

```

"Brisk," Liora said. "Right."

The mooncalf sneezed into her sleeve.

Silver dust bloomed across the fabric in the shape of tiny stars.

Liora looked at it. Then at Grindle. Then at Pollard.

"Well," she said. "At least I'm finally accessorized."

The trip to Briarwick took one municipal handcart, three rejected requisition requests, and the personal theft of a tartan office blanket from the Lost Property cupboard.

Liora did not think of it as theft. She thought of it as emergency textile reassignment.

The mooncalf lay curled in the cart, wrapped in the blanket with only its nose, ears, and one chipped crescent horn showing. Every few minutes it tried to nibble the moon-painted key, which Liora took as a good sign because wanting to eat important legal artifacts suggested at least some will to live.

The city thinned as they went north.

Grey municipal buildings gave way to crooked shops with striped awnings, then soot-stained terraces, then allotments where retired witches grew argumentative pumpkins under glass bells. The afternoon softened. Rain clouds moved over the rooftops, but the western sky held a band of pale gold.

Liora pushed the cart uphill.

The cart squeaked.

The mooncalf hiccuped.

Her left shoe had started rubbing.

"This," she told the bundled creature, "is the part of the heroic tale people leave out. Very few ballads mention incline management."

The mooncalf blinked.

"I know. Shocking."

A boy selling roasted chestnuts at the corner took one look at the blanket bundle and asked, "Is that a dog?"

"No," Liora said.

"Is it supposed to glow?"

"Probably more than it currently does."

"Cool."

"That is one possible interpretation."

He gave her a paper twist of chestnuts for free, because children were often better at triage than city departments. Liora thanked him and tucked them into her pocket. The mooncalf sniffed hopefully.

"Not for you. Apparently ordinary feed worsens Lunar Depletion."

The mooncalf gave her a look of profound betrayal.

"You have known me for forty minutes."

Its ears sagged.

"Oh, don't do that."

It did it harder.

Liora sighed and made a note in her head: mooncalves weaponized ears.

By the time Briarwick's lane appeared, the city was behind them and the road had become a ribbon of pale stones between hedges thick with late summer briar. The air changed first. It lost the office smell of ink, dust, and damp wool. It gained moss, rain, leaf-mold, and something faintly sweet beneath it all.

Not flowers.

Memory.

The gate stood at the end of the lane, half-swallowed by ivy.

An arch of green-black iron curved overhead, its letters hidden beneath lichen. Liora set the cart brake, stepped forward, and peeled ivy away with both hands.

**\*\*BRIARWICK MONSTER NURSERY\*\***

Beneath that, smaller:

*\*Small claws. Soft hearts. Second chances.\**

For a moment, she was eight years old again, sitting cross-legged on her aunt's kitchen floor with the biscuit tin in her lap, tracing the painted mooncalf on the lid while Aunt Rhea told her that monsters were mostly children no one had understood in time.

Then the gate creaked open by itself.

Only a foot.

Then it stuck.

The system chimed.

...

[LOCATION DISCOVERED]

Briarwick Monster Nursery  
Facility Status: Condemned  
Current Comfort: 0  
Habitat Stability: 2%  
License Compliance: 11%  
Resident Count: 1 pending intake

Available Functional Areas:

- Front Hall: dusty but emotionally promising
- Moonwell Habitat: damaged
- Kitchen: unknown
- Nursery Ledger: dormant
- East Wing: locked
- West Wing: do not lick walls

Immediate Task:

Stabilize Lunar Mooncalf before moonrise.

...

Liora stared at \*emotionally promising\*.

“That is not a measurable category.”

The panel shimmered.

...

Disagree.

...

She felt, despite everything, a smile tug at her mouth.

The gate refused to open wider until she put her shoulder into it. With a groan, a shower of leaves, and one alarming metallic shriek, Briarwick admitted its new custodian.

The nursery waited beyond.

It was not dead.

That was Liora’s first thought.

Abandoned, yes. Overgrown, absolutely. Condemned, with enthusiasm. But not dead.

The main building sat in the hollow below, a long stone-and-timber house wrapped around a central glasshouse whose many panes caught the sinking light. Several were cracked. Vines crawled over the roof. A chimney leaned at an angle that suggested either structural failure or personality. To the left, a pond lay under a skin of green scum. To the right, a row of smaller habitats stood dark and shuttered, their painted signs faded: \*BURROW ROOM\*, \*BASKING NOOK\*, \*FEATHER RUN\*, \*QUIET DEN\*.

A weather vane shaped like a tiny dragon turned slowly though there was no wind.

The mooncalf lifted its head from the cart.

For the first time since Liora had seen it, its ears pricked forward.

“Oh,” Liora whispered. “You know this place.”

The mooncalf made a thin, questioning sound.

“Or you want to.”

That was enough.



She pushed the cart down the path.

Weeds grabbed at the wheels. Brambles tugged her skirt. Twice she had to stop and free the blanket from ambitious thorns. Near the front steps, a stone gargoyle no larger than a bread loaf watched her approach with narrowed eyes.

Its plaque read: \*BERTRAM — DOOR WARDEN\*.

“Good afternoon,” Liora said, because Aunt Rhea had always insisted manners cost nothing and often confused the unpleasant.

The gargoyle’s stone eyes shifted.

“Mm,” it said.

Liora froze.

The mooncalf froze.

A pigeon on the roof made a rude noise and flew away.

“Did you just say mm?” Liora asked.

Bertram considered.

“Mm.”

“Right. I’m Liora Vale. Emergency custodian.”

“Mm.”

“This is a mooncalf.”

The mooncalf sneezed silver dust over the tartan blanket.

Bertram’s stone eyebrows rose a fraction.

“Mm.”

“I don’t suppose you know where the moonwell is?”

The gargoyle lifted one stubby stone wing and pointed to the left without otherwise moving.

“Thank you.”

“Mm.”

“Very helpful.”

“Mm.”

“Good talk.”

The front door opened when Liora touched the key to the lock.

Warm green-gold light ran through the woodgrain and vanished into the house. The door swung inward on a sigh.

The smell rolled out first: dust, old herbs, cold ashes, dried hay, and beneath it a ghost of cinnamon.

The front hall was a cathedral of clutter.

Hooks lined the walls at three heights: adult, child, and something with wings. A cracked umbrella stand held three walking sticks, one butterfly net, and a sword with a knitted cozy over the blade. A message board hung beside the door, its old notices curling at the corners.

\*No chasing inside.\*

\*Basilisks must wear soft blinkers during story hour.\*

\*If the floor purrs, inform Matron.\*

A round desk sat beneath the staircase, and on it lay a great leather-bound book furred with dust.

The Nursery Ledger.

Liora wanted, very badly, to open it.

The mooncalf shuddered.

Moonrise was coming.

“Later,” she told the ledger.

The ledger’s cover gave a tiny offended thump.

“Don’t start. I’m triaging.”

The moonwell habitat lay through a side door painted midnight blue.

Inside, the air was cool. The room had once been beautiful. Liora could see that immediately, and the seeing hurt.

The ceiling was a dome of old glass set with silver tracking mirrors. Most hung crooked. One had fallen and cracked across the floor like frozen water. Moonvine curled in dry ropes around trellises. At the center of the room stood a shallow stone basin—the moonwell itself—carved with phases of the moon.

It was empty.

No water. No light. Only dust and a dead moth.

The mooncalf tried to stand in the cart, failed, and made a small distressed bleat.

Liora’s stomach clenched.

“Right,” she said. “No panic. We are not panicking. Panic is just urgency wearing noisy shoes.”

The system, thankfully or rudely, agreed.

...

[URGENT CARE TASK: Moonwell Stabilization]

Resident: Lunar Mooncalf

Time to Moonrise: 1 hour, 16 minutes

Required:

1. Clear basin obstruction.
2. Restore reflective surface.
3. Align at least three moon mirrors.
4. Prepare mineral milk substitute.
5. Provide stable warmth and low-noise handling.

Available Resource:

Hearthglow: 0

Potential Hearthglow Sources:

- Clean habitat with care.
- Restore intended function.

- Reduce creature distress.
  - Offer warmth freely given.
- ...

"Clean an entire magical habitat in an hour," Liora said. "Wonderful. I was worried this would be difficult."

The mooncalf looked at her.

"That was sarcasm. You'll learn."

It attempted to nibble the blanket.

"Not that."

First came the basin.

Liora rolled up her sleeves, found a broom that coughed when lifted, and swept dust, leaves, and one scandalized spider from the moonwell. The spider wore a tiny waistcoat. It gave her a look of such deep professional disappointment that she apologized twice and relocated it to the windowsill.

Next came water.

The pump in the corner gave three dry wheezes and then nothing.

"Of course," Liora said.

She checked the pipe. Rusted valve. Jammed handle. Municipal offices had taught her many things, including the exact amount of force one could apply to old equipment before it became a different problem.

She fetched the sword with the knitted cozy from the hall.

"I am not using you as a weapon," she told it. "I am using you as a lever. This is more dignified."

The sword did not object.

The valve screamed open. Water gushed into the moonwell in a brown rush, then cloudy, then clear. The basin filled. The carved moon phases shimmered beneath the surface.

The mooncalf lifted its head.

Its chipped horn glowed once.

“Good,” Liora breathed. “That’s good.”

One of the overhead mirrors creaked.

Then dropped.

Liora lunged, caught the edge with both hands, and nearly went down under the weight. The mirror was bigger than a serving tray and framed in tarnished silver. Her shoulder protested. Her shoe slipped. The mooncalf bleated.

“I’m fine,” she lied. “Everything is very controlled.”

The mirror’s reflection showed her hair escaping its pins, dust on her cheek, and a wild-eyed expression that would not have inspired confidence in a cabbage.

She hauled the mirror back into its bracket and tightened the wingnut with her fingers. One mirror aligned. Then a second. The third refused until she threatened it with paperwork.

“Don’t test me,” she told it. “I know twelve ways to file a compliance note.”

The mirror clicked into place.

A thin beam of evening light slid through the dome and struck the moonwell.

The water turned silver.

The mooncalf struggled upright in the cart, ears forward, nose trembling.

“Almost,” Liora said. “Mineral milk substitute. What does one put in mineral milk substitute?”

The system remained silent.

“Helpful.”

She ran to the kitchen.

Unknown had been a generous assessment.

The kitchen was large, warm in memory if not in fact, with a black iron stove, a long table, hanging copper pans, and shelves full of jars. Unfortunately, most of the labels had faded. One cupboard contained six bowls, three cracked mugs, and a small blue teapot shaped like a sleeping tortoise. Another contained dried roots, salt, oats, powdered chalk, and a jar labelled \*DO NOT FEED TO ANYTHING WITH A SHADOW\*.

Liora left that one alone.

She found an old nursery handbook in a drawer beneath a stack of moth-eaten towels. The title read: \*Juvenile Lunar Ungulates: Feeding, Soothing, and Acceptable Chewing Objects\*.

“Thank you, dead competent person,” she whispered.

The recipe was handwritten in the margins.

\*Emergency mineral milk: warm goat milk if available. If not, oat steep, clean water, pinch moon salt, crushed pearl barley, warmed silver spoon for resonance. Never boil. Never whistle while stirring. Mooncalves find it judgmental.\*

“No whistling. Fine.”

There was no goat milk. There was oat. There was water. There was something in a blue crock labelled \*MOON SALT — STOP USING FOR SOUP, BARNABY\*. There was pearl barley. There was a silver spoon in the drawer, black with tarnish.

Liora worked quickly.

Oat steep. Pinch of moon salt. Barley crushed under the spoon. Warmed over the stove once she convinced the stove that yes, she was authorized, no, she did not have a current kitchen badge, and yes, if it helped, she would compliment its knobs.

The stove glowed to life.

“Lovely knobs,” she said.

The stove preened. There was no other word for the way its brass handles gleamed.

The mixture warmed into a pale, creamy liquid with a faint pearlescent sheen. It smelled like porridge, rain, and the moment just before falling asleep.

She carried it back to the moonwell in a chipped bowl.

The mooncalf tried to climb out of the cart and tangled itself in the blanket.

“No, no, wait.”

Liora lifted it carefully.

It weighed less than it should have. That angered her all over again. Not the hot, office kind of anger that made her want to argue with Grindle until his moustache resigned. A quieter anger. A useful one.

She carried the mooncalf to the basin's edge and sat on the floor with it half in her lap, the bowl in both hands.

"Here," she murmured. "Small sips."

The mooncalf sniffed the bowl.

Its ears tilted suspiciously.

"It's not a chestnut, I know. We're all disappointed."

The mooncalf sneezed.

The milk rippled.

"Small sip," Liora said again, softer.

It drank.

Only a mouthful at first.

Then another.

Its throat moved. Its trembling eased by a fraction. A faint glow spread along the unchipped horn, then across the broken one, silver light filling the crack like kindness finding a place to settle.

Liora did not move.

Her knees hurt. Her back ached. Dust tickled her nose. Her skirt was damp from moonwell water. The office blanket smelled like old umbrellas.

The mooncalf drank until half the bowl was gone, then leaned its narrow head against her wrist.

Its eyes closed.

The system chimed.

Not loudly.

Gently.

...

[CARE EVENT COMPLETE]

Event: First Stabilization

Resident: Lunar Mooncalf

Outcome: Stable

Bond Trust: 3% → 18%

Panic-Bound reduced to Wary

Lunar Depletion reduced to Mild

Nursery Comfort: 0 → 1

Moonwell Habitat Stability: 0% → 12%

Skill Unlocked: Gentle Handling I

You may soothe panic-bound juvenile creatures through touch, tone, and stable warmth.

New Resource Generated:

Hearthglow +4

Custodian Note:

Care is not soft. Care is structural.

...

Liora stared at the last line until the words blurred.

Care is structural.

Not sentimental. Not indulgent. Not naive. Structural.

A thing you built. A thing that held.

The moonwell gave a small, liquid pulse. The three aligned mirrors caught the first true thread of moonrise and poured it into the basin. Silver light spread across the water, across the floor, across Liora's damp skirt and tired hands.

The mooncalf sighed.

It was a tiny sound.

It changed the whole room.

Liora let out a breath she felt she had been holding for years.



“Well,” she whispered. “That’s one.”

The mooncalf opened one eye.

“You need a name,” she said.

It blinked.

“I’m not calling you Lunar Mooncalf on forms. That’s not a name. That’s a committee.”

One ear twitched.

“Mo?”

No response.

“Pearl?”

The mooncalf yawned.

“Very honest. Thank you.”

She looked at the crescent glow along its horn, the way moonlight pooled in the chipped place and made the damage beautiful without pretending it had not happened.

“Cress,” she said.

The mooncalf’s ear flicked forward.

“Cress?”

It nudged her wrist with its damp nose.

The system gave a soft chime.

...

[RESIDENT NICKNAME REGISTERED]

Lunar Mooncalf: Cress

Bond Trust: 18% → 19%

Warning:

Nickname affection may result in increased emotional liability.

Proceed?

...

Liora snorted.

"Too late."

The system did not argue.

She sat there until the moon rose fully and the nursery's old glass dome turned the light into a soft silver rain. Cress curled beside the moonwell, nose tucked under one long ear, hooves folded awkwardly beneath him. Every few breaths, his chipped horn glowed.

Liora should have been exhausted.

She was exhausted.

But beneath the exhaustion was something bright and dangerous.

Purpose, possibly.

Or dehydration.

She would investigate after finding tea.

She carried the empty bowl back to the kitchen, located the tortoise teapot, and discovered a tin of blackleaf tea behind a jar of dried lavender. The tea was stale, but hot water forgave many sins. She made a cup strong enough to qualify as a personality and returned to the front hall.

The Nursery Ledger sat on the desk where she had left it.

Its cover thumped once.

"Fine," Liora said. "I'm here."

She opened it.

Pages fluttered by themselves, shedding dust and the faint scent of hay. Ink stirred. Lines wrote themselves across the first blank page.

**\*\*BRIARWICK MONSTER NURSERY\*\***

**\*\*Emergency Custodian: Liora Vale\*\***

**\*\*License Trial: 6 days, 23 hours, 11 minutes\*\***

**\*\*Residents: 1\*\***

**\*\*Staff: 0\*\***

**\*\*Comfort: 1\*\***

**\*\*Compliance: 13%\*\***

**\*\*Current Threats: deferred maintenance, unpaid fees, emotional attachment, unknown noises in walls\*\***

Liora took a sip of tea.

“Unknown noises in walls?”

Something knocked.

She froze.

It came again.

Knock.

Knock.

Knock.

Not from outside.

From inside the nursery.

Specifically, from beneath the round desk.

Liora set down the tea.

The Ledger flipped several pages at once. A new system panel bloomed above it, green-gold and deeply unbothered.

...

[UNREGISTERED EGG DETECTED]

Location: Front Hall — under reception desk

Estimated Hatch Time: 11 minutes

Species: Unknown

Risk: Messy

Recommended Actions:

- Prepare towel.
- Do not scream.

- Consider breakfast arrangements.

Warning:

Egg is listening.

...

Liora slowly crouched.

Beneath the desk, tucked in a nest of old receipts, dust, and one missing mitten, sat an egg the size of a melon.

It was green.

It had spots.

It was wearing a crack like a smile.

From the moonwell room, Cress gave a sleepy little bleat.

The egg knocked again.

Liora looked at the key in her palm, the ledger on the desk, the moonlight filling the ruined nursery, and the impossible green egg preparing to become her second problem before she had even found clean towels.

Then she smiled.

"Oh," she said softly. "We are going to need a bigger form."